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Section Title(S)

Men and Constraints on Polygyny • Women Investing in Children

In order to elucidate the effects of polygyny on women's and men's ability to invest in their children's education and future earnings, we selected eighteen women from Håkansson's interviews (see Håkansson, 1988). These were the women whose marriages took place between 1945 and 1962. The rationale for choosing these women was to examine those cohorts who grew up during a time period when secondary school education became important for obtaining salaried employment, that is, from the middle 1960s. These constitute a nonrandom, opportunistic sample of interviews with farming families. Families in which the husband had long-term employment requiring training and education and significant business investments are not included. The husbands in the families selected had been or were employed at the time of the study in unskilled wage employment, and their wives were farmers. They were fairly representative of the average economic standard of a rural Gusii family.²

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These families have children of varying ages, which made it necessary to compare only those children who had already completed compulsory primary school education at the time of the study. The results show that of nine polygynously married women, only one had been able to send half or more of her children of age to secondary and/or further education. Of the nine monogamous families, eight had put the majority of their children of age through secondary school and beyond.³ Thus, women in monogamous families today may face a more secure old age in terms of potential assistance from income earning children than those in polygynous unions.⁴ In the monogamous unions the wives had been able to utilize more of their own income from farm production and more of their husbands' incomes for their children's education. The reasons for success in paying school fees was in some cases that the husband was dead or that the husband had decided not to divert income for a second marriage.

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Men and Constraints on Polygyny

Although polygyny has continued to be prestigious among men, its importance as a means for political and economic advancement has declined. As will be discussed, the role of polygyny as an ideal and a practice, its causes and consequences, and the motivations behind it are complex and contradictory. The continued prestige of marrying polygynously is expressed as “becoming an important man in the clan.” According to some male informants, local government-appointed *etureti* elders are normally polygynists. Having many wives, it is thought, shows that they can control many people and are therefore equipped to solve disputes in their communities.

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While younger men in their thirties and forties are not immune to the sense of eminence it confers in rural areas, there is a sense that polygyny is not economically and socially practical in today's world. In the 1950s, to be a monogamist was, for older men, a source of ridicule and jokes at beer parties, and monogamous men were often urged to take a second wife. We suspect that the old ideal of attaining  262 “immortality” by founding a lineage still forms a part of the motivations for polygyny. If he has many sons and grandsons, a man's descendant lineage and the place where he lived may be named after him.

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2. They came from families that were poor or regular farmers, that is, whose parents had two to four acres of land and little formal education and subsisted on a mixture of agriculture, small scale food marketing, and casual labor.
3. Parkin (1978, pp. 82–85) in his study of urban Luo in Nairobi stressed that polygynous marriages adversely affect the ability of such families to educate their children. Luo wives insist on the ideal of equal division of a husband's resources for the education of all children. This diminishes the chances of providing school fees for any one child's secondary education. In polygynous families it is often the mother who contributes substantially to her children's higher education through trade and the sale of cash crops.
4. The difference in educational success is not related to number of children. There was very little difference in the number of children between the two groups. The lowest number of children was five. One polygynously and one monogamously married woman each had five children. The rest had seven to ten children.

Human Relations Area Files
755 Prospect Street
New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu

